

ious combinations of Cold Start—manoeuvres in deserts, in the plains of Punjab, offensives launched by the strike corps and pivot corps and air-land battles along with the air force.

"By readying itself in time for any military operation, the army is giving the political leadership more options," says Gurmeet Kanwal, director, Centre for Land Warfare Studies. The decision to go to war will still be a political one and Cold Start is only one of the many options the army brings to the table, even if it is unsure of it being accepted. "Today, the army is ready to launch an offensive virtually from the line of march, but is the political and security decision-making apparatus coping with advancements on the ground?" asks a senior army official. The National Security Council, meant to

none and a massive Parakram-like mobilisation in response to provocations from Pakistan. On the other hand, if the new doctrine were fully operationalised, it makes the resort to force more likely. Depending on the nature of the provocation or future crisis, the existence of Cold Start as an option could increase public pressure on the government to use force in response to a specific incident," says Walter C. Ladwig from the Oxford University and an author on a paper on the doctrine.

Analysts also point out to its inherent weakness. Pakistan's strike formations are closer to the international border and can be mobilised in just 24 hours. Over the past decade, it has put in new counter strategies including creating a corps reserve for each of its four holding corps. Moreover, an oper-

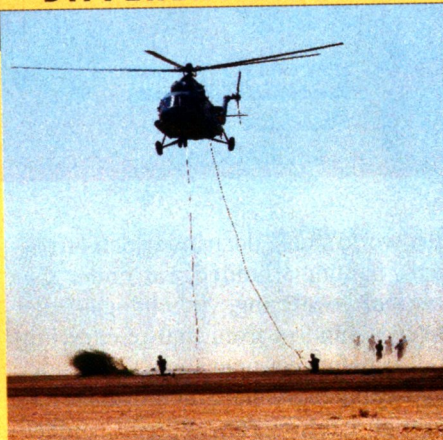
The Indian Army has inducted impressive firepower like the Smarch, radars, satellites and unmanned aerial vehicles that ensure continuous coverage of enemy territory. "Technology has enabled us to reduce our attacking ratios from 9:1 (nine troops for every enemy soldier) to 2.5:1," says Thamburaj.

Yet, the speed of technology induction may not be keeping pace with the fast-paced doctrine. The army has a long equipment wishlist and is wrestling with a grave shortage of helicopters to speedily insert troops behind enemy lines, an essential aspect of fast-paced operations. It needs to airlift a brigade (3,000) troops, which requires at least 100 helicopters but the MI-17s operated by the IAF can only ferry half a battalion or 400 troops.

DIFFERENT STROKES

OLD STRATEGY

- Mobilise, build-up, hit. Offensive power instruments like air force, army and the navy operate sequentially.
- It took 12-22 days to mobilise formations for offensive operations.
- Pivot or holding corps would get into position and wait for strike corps to arrive. Logistics pause.
- Different zones of enemy defences addressed sequentially.



COLD START

- Hit, mobilise, hit harder. All offensive power instruments—air force, army and navy—attack tactical and strategic targets simultaneously.
- Operations start within 24 hours.
- Pivot corps already in position, launch operations without waiting for arrival of strike corps. Day and night operations with no logistics pause.
- All enemy zones are attacked simultaneously.

study all the options and advise the prime minister on options in a crisis, has not met in five years.

As the saying goes, no plan survives contact with the enemy and Cold Start may be no exception. The primary concern is whether a conventional war, however limited, is possible in a nuclearised environment. "There is always space for conventional war below the nuclear threshold (the point above which the adversary will launch nuclear weapons)," says Lt-General Noble Thamburaj, general officer commanding, Southern Command.

The development of the doctrine seems to have contradictory effects. "On the one hand, it seems to increase the range of options available to the political establishment by allowing gradations in the use of force between

LONG HAUL: Few choppers

ation launched by a holding formation, without waiting for the strike corps, could actually weaken the line leading to a counter attack from the other side.

The innovative mobilisation strategy may take years to fully realise because the army is not yet adequately mechanised—a prerequisite for mobile warfare. "You cannot fight mobile, high-speed wars if you have an unmechanised army. The formations that are to initiate Cold Start are all infantry with a bit of armour and some armoured brigades. The strike formations are strike only in name as only about 40 per cent of the three strike corps are mechanised (troops in armoured personnel carriers)," says defence analyst Ravi Rikhye.

Equipment shortage also plagues the creation of three new Independent Battle Groups under each strike corps.

However, the mere existence of such a doctrine could contribute to deterrence. "Pakistan would not necessarily be able to count on slow mobilisation times or outside intervention from the United States to prevent a retaliation to a given provocation in the future," says Ladwig.

"Cold Start is a bit like the stock market. If you have the capacity to take risks, you will make good gains, but if you're unwilling to take them, you can choose the low-risk option, of putting your money in a fixed deposit with steady returns," says former vice chief Lt-General Vijay Oberoi. A conundrum which the decision makers must take into account. ■